

- ↔ 14–18in (35.5–45cm)
- ⚖ 1–9lb (0.5–4kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐭 Rodents, snakes, frogs, fruit



SW. and S. Asia

▽ STRATEGIC COMBAT

Mongoose defeat cobras by agility and endurance—dodging away each time a snake strikes, then biting into its skull once it tires.



Sloth bear

Melursus ursinus



The sloth bear is a solitary, elusive forest dweller, but the slurping sounds it makes when feeding can be heard up to 650 ft (200 m) away. These shaggy-looking members of the bear family use their long, curved claws to dig out ants, termites, and other insects, sucking them up through flexible lips and a special gap in their

teeth, while closing their nostrils to prevent stings. Like many bear species, they also raid beehives for honey. Sloth bears mate during the summer months. Females bear one or two cubs, which stay with their mother for up to four and a half years. They are the only bears known to carry cubs on their backs.

- ↔ 5–6 ft (1–1.9 m)
- ⚖ 110–320 lb (50–145 kg)
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🐜 Ants, termites, fruit, honey



S. Asia



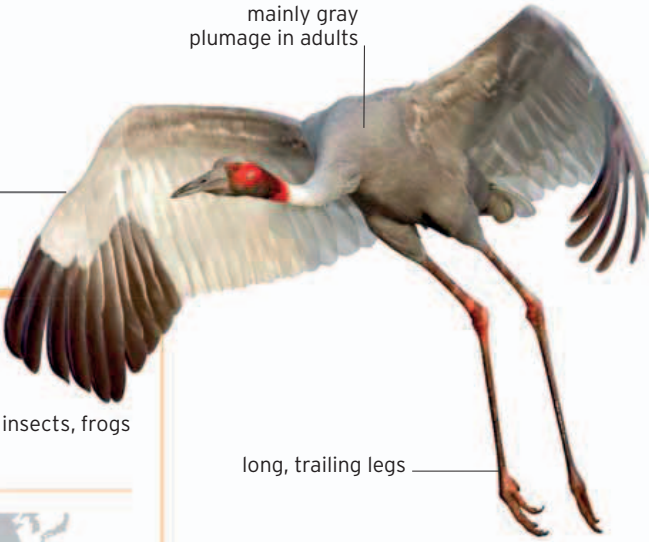
▷ LONG, MOBILE SNOOT

Sloth bears use their nostrils to blow dust and earth out of the way before sucking up insects to eat.

Sarus crane

Grus antigone

mainly gray plumage in adults



long, trailing legs

- ↔ 5 ft (1.5 m)
- ⚖ 14 lb (6.5 kg)
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🐷 Roots, tubers, insects, frogs



S. and SE. Asia, N. Australia

At 6 ft (1.8 m), the sarus crane is the tallest flying bird on earth. It has dramatic displays: rhythmic bowing leading into two-footed leaps, with head extended and wings half open, while making loud trumpeting calls. The sarus crane is a declining bird, being confined to wet paddy fields and reservoir edges as marshlands are drained and rice cultivation becomes more intensive. Breeding pairs occupy territories and forage for aquatic plants, insects, and frogs, mainly in natural vegetation, but occasionally in cultivated fields.

△ TAKING OFF

Although long legs and broad wings power its take off, the sarus crane uses a steady, efficient action once airborne.